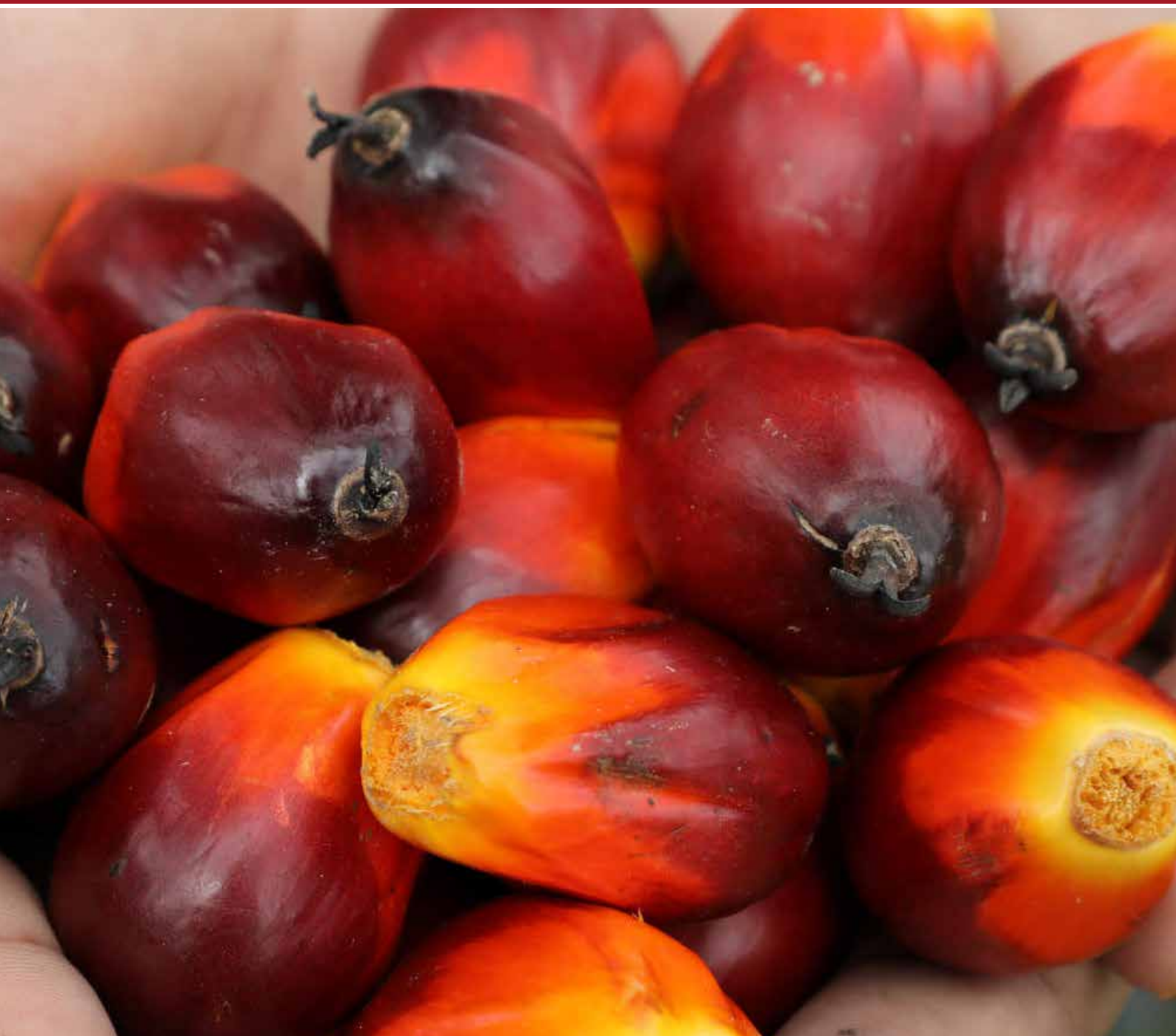


Issue #01

# EXPERIENCES FROM THE FIELD SERIES

ISSUE 1: April 2022    **Buvuma Oil Palm Project Experiences**



THE REPUBLIC OF UGANDA

GOU/IFAD



National Oil Palm Project  
(NOPP) Uganda



**IFAD**

Investing in rural people



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## LIST OF ACRONYMS

|         |       |                                         |
|---------|-------|-----------------------------------------|
| GEMPs . | ..... | Good Environmental Management Practices |
| PPE     | ..... | Personal Protective Equipment           |
| NOPP    | ..... | National Oil Palm Project               |



# Foreword

## Disclaimer:

While the experiences have been documented by the stakeholders from Buvuma Island in regard to their interaction with the project, this work has been made with Financial Assistance from IFAD and the Government of Uganda. However, it remains under the sole responsibility of its author(s) and does not reflect the ideas and the views of the IFAD or government of Uganda. The user should make his/her own evaluation as to the appropriateness of any statements, arguments, experimental methods and techniques described herein.

The documented experiences in this booklet were selected and written by the farmers and key stakeholders participating in the National oil Palm Project (NOPP), Buvuma District. They have been developed using the "Experience Capitalization" approach of Knowledge Management. "Experience capitalization" is the process through which an experience is identified, validated and documented, leading to lessons learning, identification of potential good practices and their subsequent adoption.

## Foreword:

The National Oil Palm Project (NOPP) is a Government of Uganda (GoU) effort to increase Production of Vegetable Oil in Uganda. The National Oil Palm Project is intended to sustainably increase rural incomes through opportunities generated by the establishment of an



efficient Oil Palm industry that complies with modern environmental and social standards, resulting into inclusive rural transformation through Oil Palm investment. I am pleased that National Oil Palm Project is publishing this new Our Story series, which is a complementary instrument alongside other efforts and products being developed by National Oil Palm Project to systematize and disseminate its results and lessons to the wider internal and external publics. Each issue of the Our Story will feature experiences from the project areas.

Our Story Issues shall be published quarterly and shall draw on evidence from a range of sources, including a thorough review of existing documentation, interviews with the teams that are implementing the project, in some cases, additional fieldwork, including interactions with beneficiaries. National Oil Palm Project is committed to strengthening its ability to learn, generate knowledge and provide evidence about what works and what does not, with the aim of improving the development effectiveness of its activities, as well as making available its experience to others in the development community. I wish you a good reading.

I wish you a good reading.

**CONNIE MAGOMU MASABA**

**Project Manager - National Oil Palm Project**

# EDITOR'S WORD

## *Dear Readers*

You are most welcome to this edition of Experiences From The Field Series publication. The experiences shared have been documented by the stakeholders in Buvuma district that have been directly or indirectly involved in the implementation of National Oil Palm Project (NOPP). This is a 10-year project being implemented by Ministry of Agriculture, Animal Industry and Fisheries (MAAIF) with financial support from International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD) and the Government of Uganda. In 2019, NOPP launched a Knowledge Management (KM) strategy, aimed at motivating people to generate, use and share good practices, learning and expertise to improve the project's efficiency, credibility and development effectiveness. Thus compelled to work together with stakeholders on facilitating learning among key stakeholders, through generation of knowledge and documentation.

The experiences have been documented using experience capitalization approach where farmers and participants in the field sat together shared lessons and generated their experiences for documentation from a series of engagements and interactions with NOPP.

"Experiences

From The Field Series" on Oil Palm development in Uganda, come at a time when the world is experiencing an acute shortage of oil palm and palm oil products for two major reasons. Firstly, there has been a rise in crude oil pump-prices in producer countries and in importing countries, hence making freight transportation of crude oil palm from Malaysia and Indonesia to Uganda, expensive. Relatedly, oil palm producer countries especially Indonesia—the world's largest producer/exporter—is replacing her old plantations with new ones, so withholding crude palm oil for her own domestic use. This has sent world palm oil prices skyrocketing.

Secondly, Uganda today imports over 380,000 Metric Tons of vegetable oil [mostly oil palm in 2019/2020 statistics] worth US\$290m a year [according to Agriculture Minister, Hon. Frank Tumwebaze]. These are no small amounts of oil palm nor expenditures of forex on crude oil palm imports!

Oil Palm has also created thousands of direct and indirect jobs with many people working in plantations owned by OPUL plus out-growers. Mago-mu says by early 2022, oil palm farmers earned up to Shs 5bn/. Currently, a kilo of fresh fruit bunches are

sold at Shs 869 from Shs 857 in April 2022, in Kalangala—where the project was first implemented. Smallholder farmers supply on average 6.9m kilos of fresh fruit earning a gross income of Shs6 bn monthly. Commercial oil palm growing in Uganda started in Kalangala in 2006 and harvesting started in 2010 with crude palm oil shipped to Jinja where BID-CO-refinery makes cooking oil and soap among other products. Oil palm trees mature at four years and are harvested every 10 days for 25 years after which farmers shall replant. Ugandans now have a reliable monthly income for 25 straight years.

These and other outcomes from Uganda's oil palm industry, give credence to the relevance and appropriateness of this subsector to our country's economy. NOPP has many opportunities to translate the current big demand for oil palm products and bi-products, to assure the nation of future management of national vegetable oil needs. We encourage you to read, learn and where applicable use the lessons for transformation of our communities through oil palm growing and other series of lessons at hand.

**Anthony Wanyoto**  
**Project Knowledge**  
**Management and**  
**Communication Officer,**  
**NOPP.**



# SEEING-IS-BELIEVING FOR BAVUMA TO KALANGALA COMPLETELY CHANGED SKEPTICISM ON OIL PALM



## BUVUUMA:

When Oil palm was planned and introduced, many Ugandans were skeptical, least of all residents on Buvuuma Island, one of the project areas. But seeing-is-believing is a powerful tool in mindset change that helped the Bavuma, report Gladys Nalunkuma, Leticia Namukaja, Deo Nsubuga, Cyrus Lukoma, Fred Kyesswa & Peter Kizza.

Until they visited Kalangala, Buvuuma farmers and their leaders didn't believe oil palm which was being planned

for their island, had widely impacted Kalangala positively. This marks the beginning of a story of transformation and mindset-change for the majority of farmers in Buvuma District. They had several unanswered questions on oil palm. As a new enterprise that was to be introduced in Buvuma, there was a lot of anxiety and skepticism among many Bavuma and especially how it would turn out.

Before the visit, Bavuma people had become resistant to oil palm-growing. They didn't want to give out their land



to the nucleus estate for oil palm, nor for out-growing. But the National Oil Palm Project (NOPP) of the Ministry of Agriculture, Animal Industry and Fisheries with partners did “first-things-first.” They organized a learning visit to Kalangala District for Buvuma farmers, farmer-leaders and District officials. This was a seeing-is-believing to Kalangala, where the oil palm enterprise has worked so well to transform livelihoods of former peasants. Over 80% of farmers involved, today earn above Shs 1.5 million per season.

Supported by NOPP staff, the Buvuma farmers, DLG staff and LCs organized

themselves, through a series of planning sessions, mobilization of potential farmers, land owners and landlords, in coordination with Kalangala oil palm growers, Kalangala District Local Government (DLG), Kalangala Oil dealers [KOPET] and Oil Palm Uganda Limited (OPUL) who endorsed the visit, prior to Buvuma undertaking the tour.



### PARTICIPANT IDENTIFICATION

First of all, participants were identified in the order of key people who could represent and bring back information to the remaining colleagues learn to start oil palm in Buvuma. Planning for the trip did not only involve the human resources but also other logistics like stationary, refreshments, airtime, transport to organize better for the learning visit. Through organized planning, the Buvuma team going to Kalangala was identified, mutual consent was arrived at who needs to represent the community.



## CHOOSING & MOBILIZING PARTICIPANTS:



*Farmers from Buvuma Islands with freshly-harvested oil-palm nuts in Kalangala Islands*

Choosing participants for the tour wasn't easy as most people in the 89,000-strong-populated island were interested. Yet logistics were limited. As a result, some core people like land-owners, potential out-growers and influential community members missed out. Looking back, the process of participant-selection was done jointly by District leaders and NOPP's technical team through meetings and focused group discussions and consensus building. The chosen by category were: farmers, landlords, political, religious, cultural and opinion leaders, technicals at district, sub-county and village levels who would learn and return to influence the negative mindsets of the majority on oil palm. Mobilizing participants was another core task that the team undertook through contacting the selected participants, via correspondences, telephone calls and letters and one on one as a follow-up.

## Challenges

There were several challenges and last-minute hurdles encountered pre and post-Kalangala study tour. Some were technical, others financial e.t.c.

- A poor phone network disabled some calls to some intended participants, coupled with failure by some participants to turn up for the tour.
- Financial limitation restricted numbers e.t.c.
- Some participants travelled that very day from Buvuma which delayed take off from Mukono.

Despite the challenges faced, the organizing committee deliberately agreed with the host team to ensure participants' expectations were met. These were revisited all the time to ensure clarity on the ground with OPUL, Kalangala DLG, Kalangala Out-growers Trust, and close contact with the Buvuma visiting team. Limited time to engage with all stakeholders to learn more like on the variety of opportunities at hand was another hurdle they handled through interactions. They learnt that oil palm rejects are not paid for and are not returned to the farmer;



## **OFF TO KALANGALA**

Participants met on July 2017, at 8.30 a.m at Colline Hotel, Mukono where they boarded buses to Bukakata Masaka from connecting to a Ferry that took them to Kalangala—their desired destination. In Kalangala, they first converged at OPUL offices where they learnt of oil palm fruits purchases [by OPUL] from the Growers' Trust after harvest. From OPUL, the Bavuma were divided into 4 groups and boarded buses to the oil palm plantations, farmer organizations, oil palm cooperative and to the oil palm mill factory. They were introduced to the milling process at the factory where freshly-harvested palm fruits, weighing washing and squeezing them; then separation of husks from the crude oil and more, are done.

## **BAVUMA RICH EXPERIENCES IN KALANGALA:**

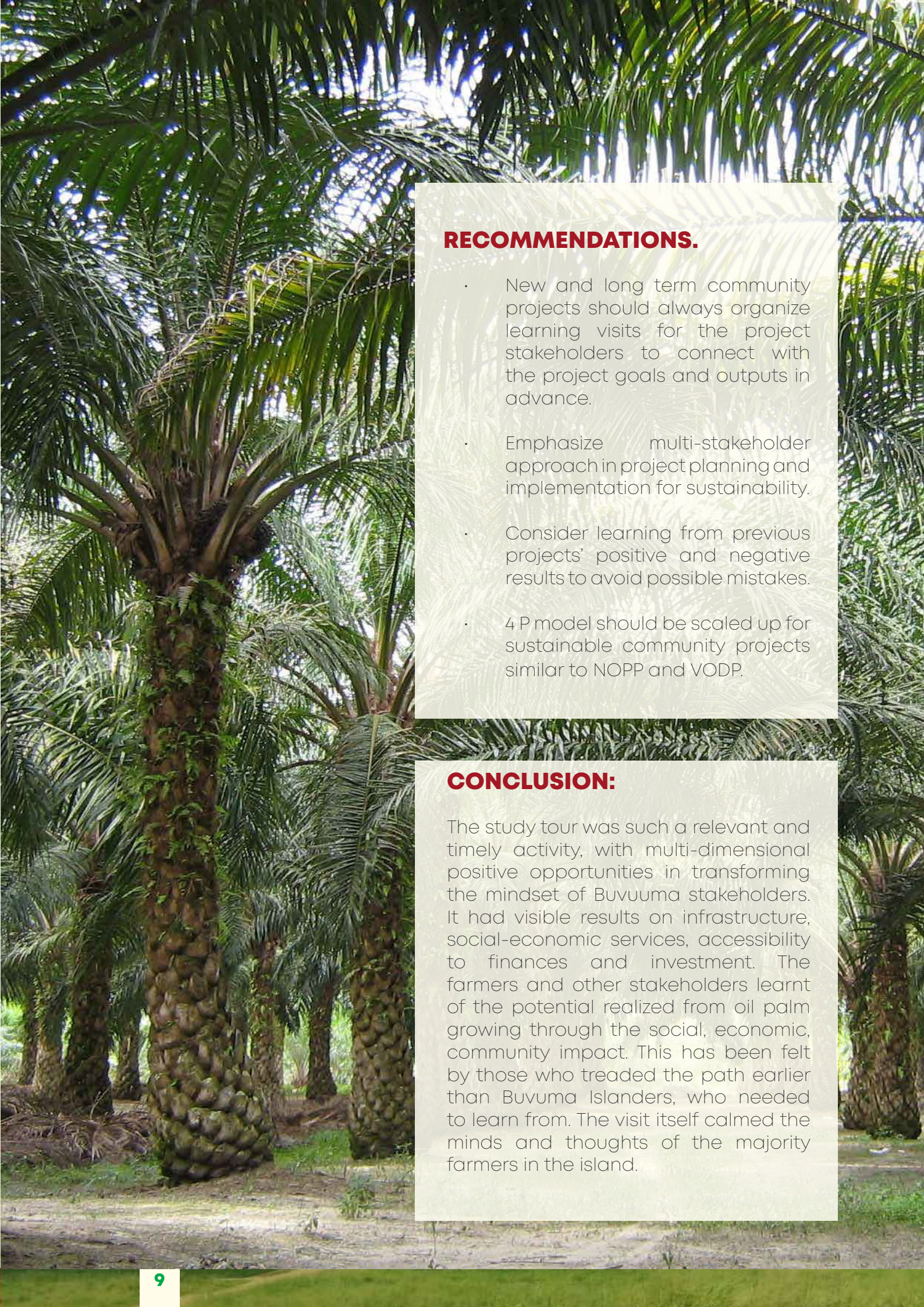
While visiting the mill and other areas, participants were given Personal Protective Equipment (PPEs) to protect them as they toured. The host teams guided visitors efficiently while they answered questions posed to them. This experience alone was amazing and led many Bavuma to think of supporting oil palm enterprise back home to transform themselves. Above all, the seeing-is-believing initiative created socialization between Buvuma and Kalangala farmers; Buvuma and Kalangala technical teams that all encouraged mutual learning and sharing.

Back in Buvuma After identifying opportunities in Kalangala, the Bavuma supported smooth implementation of the oil palm in Buvuma, as the islanders were practically convinced that oil palm growing would transform their lives. And those who had not supported the project easily gave their land to support the nucleus estate, due to good knowledge and its benefits to transform livelihoods.

## **KEY LESSONS LEARNT.**

- The farmers saw transformation and learnt that it is possible to have done back home in Buvuma.
- Learning visits are holistic in convincing and converting the lessons into reality for many.
- Multi stakeholder approach like 4P model is a key approach to project sustainability.
- The study tour supported the foundation of planning, implementation and envision of NOPP.
- Knowledge generation and sharing is a key factor in project success.





## RECOMMENDATIONS.

- New and long term community projects should always organize learning visits for the project stakeholders to connect with the project goals and outputs in advance.
- Emphasize multi-stakeholder approach in project planning and implementation for sustainability.
- Consider learning from previous projects' positive and negative results to avoid possible mistakes.
- 4 P model should be scaled up for sustainable community projects similar to NOPP and VODP.

## CONCLUSION:

The study tour was such a relevant and timely activity, with multi-dimensional positive opportunities in transforming the mindset of Buvuma stakeholders. It had visible results on infrastructure, social-economic services, accessibility to finances and investment. The farmers and other stakeholders learnt of the potential realized from oil palm growing through the social, economic, community impact. This has been felt by those who treaded the path earlier than Buvuma Islanders, who needed to learn from. The visit itself calmed the minds and thoughts of the majority farmers in the island.





# PROTECTING L.VICTORIA BUFFER ZONE: BUVUMA OIL PALM NURSERIES LEAD THE WAY

6

UN SDG

Ensure availability and sustainable management of water and sanitation for all



11

UN SDG

Make cities and human settlements inclusive, safe, resilient and sustainable



15

UN SDG

Protect, restore and promote sustainable use of terrestrial ecosystems, sustainably manage forests, combat desertification, and halt.



**By Nalunkuma Gladys, Cyrus Lukoma, Leticia Namukasa, Deo Nsubuga, Fred Kyesswa, Peter Kizza.**

Buvuma is one of Uganda's districts mapped for oil palm-growing after proof-of-viability research carried out from 1970s to-date. Four project sub-counties on the Buvuma island: Busamuzi, Buwooya, Nairambi and Buvuma Town Council, have been selected for this economic activity. However, the district faces several environmental challenges, such as knowledge gaps on what buffer-zones are, their importance and whose role it is to protect them.



*Buffer-zoning: In accordance with the National Wetlands, Riverbanks & Lakeshore Regulations (2000), requirement for a 200-metre buffer for L. Victoria in Buvuma Island/District, is observed by NOPP Nurseries*



The National Wetlands, Riverbanks and Lakeshore Regulations (2000), demand a 200-metre buffer-zone for all major lakes in Uganda, including Lake Victoria that surrounds the entire Buvuma island. The National Oil Palm Project (NOPP) under the Ministry of Agriculture, Animal Industry and Fisheries (MAAIF) has since 2019, deliberately emphasized buffer-zoning, monitoring compliance and utilization of Personal Protection Equipment (PPE) for workers in the project.

The other is restoration of identified degraded areas within the lakeshore buffer-zone by planting indigenous tree-species, as environmental protection measures in Buvuma.

.....

All constructions like roads, ferries, landing-sites and buildings are guided to ensure environmental compliance for both safety and conservation of the environment. Planning for oil palm-growing in the district took close to a decade of organization and mobilizing of the community for the economic activity. The main oil palm nursery is found at Buwangwe Village in Busamuuzi Sub-county. This is where good environmental management practices (GEMPs) safe-guarding the buffer-zones are found.

Buvuma District Natural Resources Officer, Ms. Gladys Nalunkuma, confirms this: "The oil palm nursery has been established outside the 200-metre lakeshore buffer zone. Routine guidance on compliance is provided by the District Natural Resources Officer, with overall coordination by the NOPP Environment, Health and Safety Officer. Other GEMPs include but are not limited to, acquisition of environment permits to carry out construction of key infrastructure such as the irrigation pump house and water obstructions."

“

Buffer zones are created to enhance protection of a specific conservation area, related to it. Within buffer zones, resources like a water body may be legally or customarily restricted. To a lesser degree than in the adjacent protected area so as to form a transition zone. Under NOPP, buffer-zones have mainly been along lake shores and stream-banks. Buffer zones are designated for environmental protection, and anyone intending to implement any activity within 200-meter lakeshore buffer needs permission from the National Environment Management Authority

”

“

In precautionary practices, land for oil palm nurseries was identified, surveyed, valued and compensation for land-owners done. This was accompanied by a series of environmental checks and balances. They include monitoring for Environmental Compliance across the establishment of the oil palm nurseries."

”





“Land acquisition process per establishment of the nursery and nucleus estate land was made possible through community members and local council leadership who helped in identification of the rightful land owners,” says Nalunkuma. When the rightful owners were identified, she explains, it helped NOPP to identify what was required to utilize the land and map out buffer-zones to protect key areas of environment. She adds: “Communities were sensitized on what the buffer zones are, their implications in environmental management and why it was mandatory to observe the same.”

Following the process of acquiring land for the nursery, NOPP then surveyed and valued the land that would be utilized. Communities were mobilized and sensitized about the land survey process; the activity also involved various land

title searches by land surveyors. Land surveys conducted helped the project team to define protected areas and critical habitats such as lakeshore buffer zones, wetlands and forest reserves – both central and local.

While there were several benefits associated with the good environmental management practices applied thus far, there were some challenges that limited to some extent the smooth running of the success of guarding the buffer zones. Enforcement of the environment safe guards was costly because people were generally resistant to evictions. Some people wanted compensation for land that lay within buffer zones which is contrary to the law. Also, some people that were compensated for land that genuinely belonged to them moved to settle within the buffer zones



| <b>Recommendations On GEMPs</b>                                                                                                                                                           | <b>Key lessons learnt</b>                                                                                         |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| There is need to sensitize the local communities on the GEMPs, to create proper understanding and generate community support.                                                             | • Local Communities supported buffer zoning and other environmental activities after understanding what it meant. |
| Environmental enforcement teams should work closely with the local communities to ensure ownership and sustainability in natural resources protection.                                    | • Community responsibility in terms of environmental management was understood.                                   |
| Proper natural resource management requires use of a multi-stakeholder approaches involving local council leaders, district technical personnel, communities, farmers and farmer leaders. | There is need for deliberate following on the implementation of the environmental guidelines.                     |
| Proper safeguards should be instituted for land identification and utilization for community projects like National Oil Palm Project for ownership.                                       | Regular monitoring by environmental management teams is key in enforcement if compliance.                         |
| <b>Conclusions</b>                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                   |
| Buffer-zoning is an ideal approach to ensure sustainable oil palm production.                                                                                                             |                                                                                                                   |
| Communities were less knowledgeable on environmental policies and practices.                                                                                                              |                                                                                                                   |
| Consistency in community sensitization is key in promoting the GEMPs.                                                                                                                     |                                                                                                                   |
| Farmers, chiefs, and District leaders need empowerment to ensure sustainable utilization of the local natural resources.                                                                  |                                                                                                                   |



# HOW NOPP STARTUP FUNDS, LAND COMPENSATION TRANSFORMED BUVUMA OIL PALM FARMERS

By Gwaka Brian, Maganda Yunusu, Mirimu David & Kizito Ssekyanzi.

**16** UN SDG Promote peaceful and inclusive societies for sustainable development, provide access to justice for all and build effective, accountable and inclusive institutions at all levels



**17** UN SDG : Strengthen the means of implementation and revitalize the global partnership for sustainable development



**15** UN SDG Protect, restore and promote sustainable use of terrestrial ecosystems, sustainably manage forests, combat desertification, and halt and reverse land degradation and halt biodiversity loss



For any project's implementation, acquisition of land, staff recruitment, local community acceptance and good management are not all that is needed for success. Startup funding is a key life-line for project sustainability. This is true for the activities of Uganda's National Oil Palm Project (NOPP) financed by Government and the Rome-based International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD). At inception of NOPP, Project staff worked closely with the Islanders and Buvuma farmers to secure the land. Most of it acquired belonged to individual landlords. NOPP's obligation was set up with some start-up funds for land-compensation, so that islanders release land for project work to take off. In Bulima Village, Busamuzi Sub-county, there was evidence of good community stakeholders' access to start-up funds. Several Bulima community members underwent a land-acquisition-compensation process since December

2014. The start-up funds were also established to boost income for small businesses there. This process took more than a year: December 2014 to December 2016, while some other processes are still ongoing.

Start-up compensation included a series of organized processes to access funds. These mainly are:

- Community-mobilization and sensitization;
- NOPP negotiation with willing-buyer and willing-seller before acquiring land;
- Identification of eligible farmers, that:
  - (i) had viable land;
  - (ii) that needed compensation;
  - (iii) needed to open bank accounts where compensation monies would be deposited.



In ensuring that the startup capital was extended to actual beneficiaries, there were signing of NOPP-willing-seller-willing-buyer agreements. First, this involved communication to identified beneficiaries. NOPP mobilized them through telephone calls, radio announcements, village mobile speakers and also physical reach-out in the community. Would-be-beneficiaries were documented and sensitized. They eventually accepted to sign land-sale agreements.

This community support was derived from NOPP's close-community-engagement initiative. It was a comprehensive but complicated process. But Local Council (LC) 1 Chairs, community leaders and NOPP facilitators played a vital role together for success in the land acquisition.

**Flashback:** NOPP was able to clearly identify which land they needed, how much land it was and through mutual consents, it was bought from the willing-sellers. In the engagements, LC

1 Chairpersons were hugely involved via community-mobilization processes. They fully acted as key witnesses to identify genuine landowners. Facilitators with experience in writing community land and property-related agreements were also utilized to help farmers come to a consensus to register basic land that was needed for the project, but had to be compensated first. This approach helped a lot. Knowledge was acquired on signing of agreements, mutual understanding between the willing-buyer & willing-seller through negotiations.

Many people who were initially unwilling to give in their land for oil palm project activities eventually agreed after consensus had been arrived at. This was because information about programs transparently reached the intended grassroots people, and changed mindsets of those who had declined to work or support the project in any way. Eventually majority of the community developed love for the project.

### Mechanism of applying compensation funds

- Profiling potential beneficiaries to ensure those for compensation were identified.
- Evaluation of the beneficiaries followed with proper judgement on who is compensated, how much to compensate and also why not compensate.
- Those in the wetlands and other gazetted areas needed to understand why less money was to be given or why it wouldn't be extended.
- Mapping and negotiations with farmers as due diligence on who had what land and where;
- Identifying absentee landlords and who is willing to offer the land for the project. This helped a lot to know who needed time;
- Assessment of readiness among farmers in the context of supporting the project through offer of land;
- Sensitization of farmers on the next steps, how they'll be paid, where, to who etc;
- Preparing their minds to plan for the resources that were yet to be received;



## **Challenges faced in extending startup funds for the community**

- Some sellers didn't have land agreements to enable them access start-up funds
- In the process it was funny that some of the farmers who had not secured the requirements as indicated by the project and eligibility for start up funds went ahead to present ineligible land titles that did not belong to them.
- This was because they were much interested in the palm oil project, and they knew it was highly profitable but the nature of their ownership which had no evidence would not allow benefit easily from the scheme.
- Some conflicts developed in the families on selling off land to the project especially where one of the spouses was not convinced.
- Others lacked National Identification for opening bank accounts and thus couldn't do it in time;
- Some who had been paid used up all money, and wanted to change their minds over land-sales;
- Some land-sellers were paid late due to unresolved land issues; We expected to sensitize many people yet a few turned up to meetings;
- Some didn't want to relocate even after land evaluation because they had cultural beliefs, which slowed down land access by NOPP.

## **Positive Settlements**

Many compensatees identified land elsewhere and relocated, giving way for the project to start;

Several created a good standard of living for their families;

Securing of the land for NOPP activities, agreements were signed, community members got compensated with start-up funds;

The story changed from fear by landlords of land-grabbing to amicable settlement through continuous sensitization and negotiation;

Bavuma overcame fear of the unknown with time after experiencing a new norm and practice of NOPP community engagements that settled anxiety; Some skeptics later believed after seeing lives of those who were compensated transform with NOPP startup funds;



Many community members have vividly transformed from one poor condition to a better one. This is visible in decent housing and businesses established—a litmus test for the community to understand that NOPP is a constructive project to transform lives;

Many farmers who originally had no bank accounts became compliant, joining the cash economy;

Banks were considered to be more secure because if land-sellers' money was paid in cash, it'd have been stolen from them by thugs;

There's visible economic empowerment since they could get money from palm oil growing to improve on their standards of living and transform their livelihoods; Unexpectedly, the project attracted a high number of out-growers to engage in palm oil growing;

Largely compensation funds have been put to good use, it transformed their livelihoods, transitioned them to a better living, better housing, and other investments;



### Recommendations.

*Source:* Internet

- Comprehensive sensitization campaigns need to be adopted for land compensation processes to facilitate understanding and settling community members' interests, fears, anxieties etc;
- Financial literacy is key for eligible beneficiaries of programmes like startup funds to enable them put the funds to sustainable and right use;
- Working with community leaders is essential in handling land-related complaints.



# NURSERY IS WHERE EXCELLENT OIL PALM SEEDLINGS ARE MADE—NOPP

By: Stephen Kibuuka, Justine Nansubuga, Samuel Mpiira & Rosemary Nagawa

**8** UN SDG  
Promote sustained, inclusive and sustainable economic growth, full and productive employment and decent work for all



**9** UN SDG  
Promote sustained, inclusive and sustainable economic growth, full and productive employment and decent work for all



**12** UN SDG  
Ensure sustainable consumption and production patterns



*Vigorous and healthy young oil palm seedlings undergoing inspection at a nursery in Kalangala Islands. Buvuma who are just starting this business, learnt a lot from their Kalangala counterparts with over 10 years' experience.*

For a perennial crop like oil palm, excellent quality seedlings' production serves as the vital foundation for future high-production and productivity of this commercial plantation crop in the field. And a nursery bed is where this excellence in quality starts from.

This is one of the key principles the National Oil Palm Project (NOPP) has trailblazed in Kalangala and now in Buvuma District. Since April 2019, NOPP established nursery beds in Buwangwe Village, Busamuzi sub-county on Buvuma Island, as one of the key



foundation activities. This was to support healthy oil palm seedlings' production for both nucleus and out-grower oil palm plants. While it was for learning purposes for out-growers, it was also a big determinant for successful NOPP's commercial plantations. It explains NOPP-convened trainings that were conducted numerous for all farmers participating in production of oil palm seedlings.

## **SYSTEMATIC PLANNING & PREPARATIONS**

In preparation for the establishment of the oil palm nurseries, farmers were engaged in practical trainings and equipped with knowledge on potting, planting, pest and disease management, on one hand. On the other hand, land preparation that involved de-stumping, tree-cutting and land grading & levelling. The project had to employ several approaches from which land had to be acquired, prepared, with some potting materials secured. In this process, the irrigation system installation, hiring labour to support nursery establishment were all engaged.

Nurseries were for producing and supplying high-quality healthy seedlings for both nucleus and out-grower plantations. But a nursery is not a stand-alone activity. It is only successful once there's land. Secondly, it hinges on a well-sensitized community equipped about plans of the nursery bed establishment, how it would benefit from them, and how they could contribute to its development.



## **THE LAND COMPONENT**

Land selection for the nursery bed establishment was identified. This was important to help the project access where these seedlings would be developed. It was followed by joint community stakeholders and NOPP land assessment for suitability, unencumbered access and negotiations for project acquisition [it had to be enough and without squatters e.t.c]. The land had to be mapped and surveyed (by professional government surveyors), and a survey report produced. Guidance on which land would be most suitable for utilization followed. Buffer zones were established as part of environmental conservation.

Land acquisition was followed by compensation. While land was put in place for project activities like a nursery, there was evidence of some community members re-occupying already-acquired land especially the frustrated landless community members. This was shocking because some of those that were compensated but misused their money are among the people that reoccupied the demarcated land for oil palm nursery. The required land





*A large, well-managed nursery in Buvuma islands where National Oil Palm Project put in good agricultural practices.*

## **NURSERY ESTABLISHMENT**

When land acquisition processes were concluded, nursery establishment followed in earnest. This involved transportation of nursery construction materials, labour and enriched [fertilized] tender soil by truck to the sites. Procurement of potting materials and seeds was done, too. Potted soil was planted seedlings with extra care. The oil palm seedlings grown in the nursery-beds when ready were transplanted. Unfortunately seedlings at a tender age came under fall army worm (FAWs) attack, but were quickly controlled by

the Project Agronomist, who supported with application of pesticides. Regular monitoring and supervisions were conducted by agronomists and NOPP technical staff to the established nurseries, to ensure compliance with good management practices such as spraying, record taking, pest surveillance in order to attain high survival rates of seedlings for the field. These measures ensured seedlings' health and sustained seedlings supply for commercial field planting



### Checklist: Materials for the oil palm nursery bed establishment used in Buvuma

| No | Item                                                     | Purpose                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|----|----------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | Potting materials and bags                               | Potting bags: Growing bags are plastic or fabric bags that are used to grow plants with shallow roots. These were used to hold seeds grow into seedlings.                                              |
| 2  | Oil palm seeds                                           | These are small parts of oil palm plant that is developed into a young plant.                                                                                                                          |
| 3  | Water for production                                     | The use of agricultural water makes it possible for the seedlings to grow into seedlings, and also helping pesticide and fertilizer mixtures.                                                          |
| 4  | Fertilizer                                               | Chemical or natural substance added to soil or land to increase its fertility.                                                                                                                         |
| 5  | Garden tools like Wheelbarrows, Spades, hoes             | These are day today tools that help carry soil, fertilizer and other materials, and mix soils for preparation to grow the seedlings.                                                                   |
| 6  | Transport means like pickups, lorries and tractors       | Pickups: Transport soil and other materials from one area to another<br><br>Tractors: Clearing and leveling the ground                                                                                 |
| 7  | Protective gears like overalls, gum boots, gloves, masks | These protect the nursery operators from pesticide, accidents while working on the farm nursery.                                                                                                       |
| 8  | Spray pumps                                              | These can be bought to extent water, pesticides and fertilizer to the seedlings.                                                                                                                       |
| 9  | Pesticides                                               | a substance used for destroying insects or other organisms harmful to cultivated plants or to animals.                                                                                                 |
| 10 | Skilled and Semi-skilled labor                           | Skilled labour: This is to provide guidance on the day today management of the seedlings.<br><br>Semi-skilled: These help in day today run of the activities at a nursery that require lots of labour. |

**Source:** National Oil Palm Project



### CHALLENGES:

- Land conflicts during the land acquisition process for the land of the nursery bed.
- Pest occurrences such as the fall army worm invaded the palm oil seedlings in the nursery.
- Levelling of the nursery bed gardens was difficult due to the irregular terrain.
- High cost of the required equipment
- The nursery bed-establishment is very labor-intensive in terms of potting, irrigation, pest control and requires specific skills.
- High water requirements lead to continuous watering hence leaching of fertilizers.

### KEY LESSONS LEARNT:

Land acquisition for the nursery bed was a longer process that needed timely engagement for negotiation with the community members for timely nursery establishment.

The pests that attacked the seedlings were not well known by the community members, since it was a newer crop in the community, the agronomists supported the healthy seedlings.

Good agricultural practices like watering, weeding are great foundations of a healthy oil palm seedling, and healthy plant.

Establishment of oil palm nursery is labour intensive due requiring both skilled labour and unskilled labour for any transportation, watering, weeding

and more.

### RECOMMENDATIONS:

Group labour should be encouraged to reduce on the burden of laborious nature of operation an oil palm nursery.

Specific capacity-building should be organized for the potential labour providers to equip them with required skills for operating nurseries and sustainability in operations.

Nursery establishment process should be handled by skilled agronomists, and supported by financially by competent institutions, in order not to compromise the quality of care required for development of the seedlings.

Step-by-step process of the community out-grower involvement in nursery establishment is essential in facilitating sustainability of the crop.

### CONCLUSION:

Establishment of the oil Palm nursery is one of the exciting yet challenging for the farmers in the District. The efforts by the project agronomists to encourage farmers come together and learn from the nursery was a great insight that would encourage farmers to take extra care in supporting the project. The nurseries established acted as good demonstration sites for the farmers to learn on care, handling, of the oil Palm seedling which skill could be replicated with support from technical team.







# LAND CONFLICT-SETTLEMENT: Great Lessons from Buvuma



In Uganda, land access, acquisition, ownership and utilization are increasingly becoming highly contested. If one properly acquires land, access may be encumbered, or even if one owns land, they may not easily or legally utilize it. These difficulties associated with land are more rampant in Buganda (central) region than anywhere else. Buvuma District in Lake Victoria, according to the Buganda kingdom legendary structure, is a County (Ssaza). In this analysis, **Salim Ruba Maiso, George Ssemugooma & Kyozira Ssemwogerere** examine lessons BUVUMA presents as far as land acquisition, ownership, access utilization for establishing a Govt and donor-funded commercial oil palm-growing is concerned.



*This land on which nurseries were established was acquired by NOPP and fully compensated by Government through the Ministry of Agriculture, Animal Industry and Fisheries (MAAIF) before the oil palms nurseries were planted. NOPP Photo*

Prior to establishment of commercial oil palm-growing in Buvuma eight years ago, the Government through the Ministry of Agriculture, Animal Industry and Fisheries (MAAIF), had to acquire land from residents. MAAIF, via

its National Oil Palm Project, physically secured land as a priority through a rigorous process. Land being a key factor of production in any investment, it was one of the 'first-things-first' NOPP had to secure for an oil palm nucleus



estate and the out-growers' scheme. This happened in Busamuzi Town Council, Nairambi and Buwooya sub-county.

In the land acquisition process, the project team realized there were several gaps that were coming along with residents' land-offers for project activities. They needed urgent redress. These were land conflicts in which some cases are unclear land boundaries, absentee landlords, land-titles not in names of those who claimed them, among others. These were serious bottlenecks. Generally, land conflict is a big challenge affecting 33-50% of Ugandan landholders (Mercy Corps 2011). Since 2007, NOPP staff, local community leaders and some elders jointly resolved land conflicts in Buvuma for the project to take off.

Such challenges not only affect landholders but entire communities, sometimes national development projects. There were delays to start of NOPP activities in Buvuma due to land acquisition challenges, at large. Land conflicts delay identification of

the right land holders in cases where there's need for compensation. Some cases uncertainty sets in on land-mapping exercises. Enabling timely compensation for community members who qualified to be compensation, is greatly encumbered. It is from the above-mentioned challenges that NOPP undertook the "resolution of conflicts" approach since land is the foundation for NOPP activities.

When NOPP's decision to acquire land materialized, community members mad-rushed to benefit from compensation-for-their-land. But land compensations required thorough checks, counter-checks and balances on ownership, clearer boundaries, proper land titles etc. Buwooya and Nairambi stand out as the best examples, where comprehensive claims for compensation and highest number of cases of land conflict settlements. The increase in the demand for land could have increased the cases and participants in the land conflicts. NOPP used phase-by-phase approach to negotiate, sensitize and resolve the conflicts.



*Such excellent outcomes (harvest) wouldn't be possible if it wasn't for good land conflict settlement. NOPP Photo*



## STRATEGIC APPROACH

Most of the community engagements to resolve land-conflicts took place in group meetings. Community members sat to discuss whatever wasn't clear about land. Meetings helped map and cite related discrepancies and easily found settlements. Community members with contestations on land were sensitized on peaceful resolution. Members were mobilized one-on-one via emissaries on motorcycles which could reach all places.

They were also reached out over radio announcements, and telephone calls to meetings on resolving differences. The majority who quickly understood the project were very supportive to conflict-resolution. NOPP's follow-up on land conflicts increased the relevance of the District land committee—as part of the land conflict resolution mechanism.

For most, involvement of LC1 & III Chairpersons, Councillors and opinion leaders worked to resolve conflicts that badly needed attention. Community members who had land-user rights issues were mapped by NOPP and brought together for support. The community leaders and members of the community helped a lot to identify those who needed help since they could not be compensated without evidence of land-ownership.

They were then mobilized for the further engagements, for discussions, and listening sessions. Negotiations which easily helped trace where the challenge were, ensued. This also called for the team and community members to allow discussions and negotiations with such categories since the project required a designated number of hectares to be able to take off. In this process,

majority of community members were sensitized about the NOPP, the opportunities available and also why land acquisition was important for the project. The awareness creation opportunities eased on the conflicts and mis-perceptions on the way the project would operate.

There were several negotiations that took place at family level on land related conflicts to create a win-win situation. This was by land committee members, LCs, Councillors and the designated NOPP team members who were involved explaining land situations like those in buffer zones. that needed compensation which the project and the land guidelines would not allow.

In some scenarios where some boundaries were not clear and more than one person claiming some section of land, they were encouraged to settle it and organize themselves. While those with titles were not in their names, were guided on the processes and procedures on how to follow it up.

## MAJOR ACHIEVEMENTS.

The community supported NOPP get the required size of land; that is 5,000 hectares secured for nuclear-estate and 2,500ha for out-growers. And majority owners got compensated. Project work on nurseries and commercial oil palm plantings is now ongoing. Most farmers have enough knowledge about NOPP and have gotten to terms with the project. Most of those who originally had land-related complaints transformed to project supporters, while others are now out-grower farmers.

Generally, NOPP empowered Buvuma community to understand and



appreciate land conflict settlement techniques. Community support to the project to settle land differences was very crucial and significant in accelerating access to compensation funds in time.

## CHALLENGES

- There were some delays in compensation payments for those with unresolved issues.
- While there were community members willing to offer land to support the project activities, there were also those that were not willing to support the project activities.
- Some residents had titles not in their names which presented transaction complications.
- Other land boundaries were unclear hence difficult on conflict resolutions.
- Some are highly-protected areas, e.g. buffer zones hence didn't qualify for compensation.
- Some land issues took longer than expected due to a long legal procedures/processes.
- The youths have no land for growing oil palm yet they were interested.

There were several issues associated with land conflicts that came up in increased numbers because they had discovered compensation funds.





# INTRODUCTION TO CASHLESS TRANSACTIONS: A New Surprise To Buvuma & 'Magnetic' Rural Phenomenon In Uganda

By Jackson Nasasa, Pantaleo Ssekindi, Samuel Loma and Hussein Dhamuzungu

**10**  
UN SDG

Reduce inequality  
within and among  
countries



**11**  
UN SDG

Make cities and  
human settlements  
inclusive, safe,  
resilient and  
sustainable



**12**  
UN SDG

Ensure sustainable  
consumption and  
production patterns



It was least expected that on the remote, deeply rural island district of Buvuma, residents would ever receive 'cashless payment' in their transactions. In this largely fish-based economy, where cash exchanges hands every minute, it was hard to think that one day when one sells the most precious of assets [land], they'd get cashless payment. Because the age-old tradition is 'sente kumukono' [cash-in-hand].

However, that day came and passed—when start-up funds for compensating landowners—were transferred on one's account in a bank of their choice. This was news! Those eligible to receive start-up funds paid by the Government of Uganda (GoU) through the Ministry of Agriculture, Animal Industry and Fisheries (MAAIF) as payment for selling their land to the National Oil Palm Project (NOPP) to introduce oil palm-growing. Cashless payment had become the *modus operandi* [mode of operation or the order of the day] in land transactions across Buvuma.





Location: Namatooke, Buwooya, Buziri and Lubaale Villages and Bowman's land all in Buwooya subcounty, Buvuma district.

### TOUGHEST CHALLENGE:

Buvuma District is one of the few areas in Uganda where there were no banks for a very long time. While it is difficult to lack such banking services at district level, it would definitely be harder at village and sub-county. It is only in the recent times that the mobile bank agents have extended their services in the District. Previously the Buvuma community had to cross to the neighbouring districts by boat or ferry, for such financial services.

Several positives happened to Buvuma as a result of introducing cashless transactions:

- A new culture of financial-inclusion of a previously subsistence peasantry community into a cash financial economy emerged;
- All those hundreds of landowners compensated for land opened and owned bank accounts for deposits, withdrawals, which were not the case before;
- Compliance with Government policy [terms & conditions] on its payments channeled via the banking system, was upheld and ushered in Buvuma;
- Financial literacy was introduced: the local community got opportunity to save and protect their monies on different types of accounts with multiple benefits and their sustenance beyond the start-up funds;
- New employment opportunities by the banks emerged in Buvuma, in

addition to commercial oil palm growing and selling;

- Interest in financial inclusion was generated even among those who were not landowners;
- A record of profiled landowners has been documented with addresses and locations;

### 'MAGNETIC STRATEGY'

The coming of NOPP and oil palm-growing to Buvuma District, has acted as a magnet that has attracted essential services like DFCU banking, communication, agro-input dealers, courts, leisure and entertainment etc. Being an island, Buvuma had for long relied on Mukono and other surrounding areas for many of these services, and it required risking boat transport to and from.

### THE PROCESS

First there was a process of seeking consent by the beneficiaries towards the process of land acquisition and compensation. From which the list of beneficiaries was disclosed by names, location. Shortly after this, the money for each beneficiary was disclosed to them and where there was need for further discussion it was conducted.

The general payment process was rigorous full of many activities, engaging many players and institutions relevant to the process. This included the office of the local leaders; LC-I, LC-III and LC-V to sensitize the community on the processes but also letters of recommendation to help them open bank accounts.



Banks were also involved in helping the beneficiaries open up their bank accounts, take them through bank transaction procedures and some few financial literacy basics which the majority of these land-owners needed. Upon agreeing on the money available for compensation, the beneficiary signs for the money to be transferred to their accounts as compensation of their land by NOPP.

Opening up bank accounts mostly required several of the landowners to present the Uganda National Identification (ID) card as beneficiary; 3 passport-size photos 20,000 shillings and Local Council 1 Chairperson verified that one is a resident to be allowed to open up an account.

Some of these requirements were not easy to get like those that did not have the National Identity cards, some who struggled to get transport to the bank and also 20,000 thousand for account opening was not easy to get for some individuals.

The system payments was safe for beneficiaries; the right person only would withdraw the money.

### CHALLENGES FACED

- Some people masqueraded as landlords to claim for compensation and were discovered; this delayed the process of payments in some way.
- Some land owners did not know the size of their land and thus not sure of how much of the payment to access.
- Bank requirements to open accounts, would charge between Shs 10,000-50,000 for only opening

- an account which led to delays
- During withdrawal, some accounts bounced and no money was gotten by the beneficiary.
- Domestic violence that resulted from getting the compensation money and a spouse chose to run away with the money.
- Division of money received brought conflicts in some families, for example if one of the parents had many children.
- Most of the beneficiaries misused the money by making unnecessary expenditures.
- Some landlords' land titles were affected by the buffer zones and thus could not get funds as expected.
- Some of the landlords didn't know where exactly their land was located and even knowing boundaries was a problem.

### RECOMMENDATIONS

- There is need for a deliberate training in the financial literacy skills to ensure sustainability of the received funds.
- More banks and financial institutions be opened up to reduce financial related risks in Buvuma District to reduce on the movement of the persons from Buvuma to mainland Districts for financial transactions.
- Further training in gender-based development approaches to facilitate collective planning and reduce Gender-Based Violence (GBV) as a result of start-up funds paid.



# SUCCESSFUL LAND ACQUISITION, PAYMENTS FOR RURAL-BASED ENTERPRISES & LARGE-SCALE INVESTMENT: Lessons From Remote Buwooya Sub-County For Uganda

Emmy Mukungu, Christopher Kyeyune and Ruth Nankanja

**12** UN SDG  
Ensure sustainable consumption and production patterns



**15** UN SDG  
Protect, restore and promote sustainable use of terrestrial ecosystems, sustainably manage forests, combat desertification, and halt and reverse land degradation and halt biodiversity loss



**16** UN SDG  
Promote peaceful and inclusive societies for sustainable development, provide access to justice for all and build effective, accountable and inclusive institutions at all levels



The United Nations (UN) Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) No. 16 states: “Promote peaceful and inclusive societies for sustainable development, provide access to justice for all and build effective,

accountable and inclusive institutions at all levels.” Juxtaposing this goal on Uganda’s remote Island of Buvuma in Lake Victoria, where in light of a new rural-based agricultural enterprise, a nascent land-acquisition and payment



system were put to test for the first time, and it succeeded! That economic enterprise—the commercial oil palm-growing—did establish an effective land-acquisition and payment system. Thanks to the National Oil Palm Project (NOPP) in the Ministry of Agriculture, Animal Industry and Fisheries. In the recent times, Buvuma has been one of the iconic districts identified for oil palm growing in Uganda. This meant a lot of back and forth preparations to create adequate factors of production, to ensure successful oil palm-growing.

The process of land acquisition became more deliberate since 2014. The institution behind this, the NOPP, a 10-year Public-Private Partnership (PPP) focuses on development of oil palm chain in the country and support farmer-production in Buvuma Island, in addition to the other districts of Kalangala, Mayuge, Masaka, Rakai and Mukono, Buikwe.

NOPP, looking to upscale the achievements made by its predecessor, Vegetable Oil Development Project (VODP), needed to acquire land: for establishment of nucleus estate and out-grower schemes in Buwooya Sub-County, Buvuma district. In Uganda, land belongs to private individuals apart from areas like Acholi, Lango, Karamoja where it is communally-owned. In Buwooya Sub-County, more than 670 acres of land were required by NOPP to support oil palm production: all of it was in private hands.

Therefore NOPP had to undertake one of the big, tough but strategic land acquisition initiatives via buying, for a nucleus estate and also attract local investors into this business. But the land acquisition experience was not a “one size fits all” nor was it a single day activity. It was rather a series of

step-by-step efficient, effective and transparent processes. It included patient engagements and massive sensitizations to create community understanding of NOPP’s goals, its need for land and the negotiation mechanisms with those who planned to sell land and the willing-seller-willing-buyer principle.

In search for land, NOPP learnt that majority of it in the District wasn’t documented, and so it was hard to know who owns what. This escalated land grabbing by the greedy that wanted to reap easy money from those who lacked awareness of the project’s compensation plan.

Also there was the challenge of absentee land lords that made it hard to enable easy transactions, in addition to lack of compliance by some land-owners to proper land documentation.

### **LAND IDENTIFICATION, MAPPING, COMPENSATIONS AND SETTLEMENT OF CONFLICT**

Field visits were conducted to scout for 670 acres in Buwooya village and physical movements in the villages was supplemented by the aid of posters and banners to mobilize the public for community engagements and sensitization. These were brought together to learn what the project is about and how they need to work together to enable the project acquire land for its activities.

Local leaders who were approached by the project team through one-on-one consultative meetings, supported the project’s land acquisition efforts. They also supported the project’s concept of investment in extensive oil palm that would impact Buvuma’s development.





Villagers' sensitization and engagement on the benefits of the oil palm crop and the need for them to sell land to the project, were also conducted. Through interactions, question and answer sessions, villagers learnt that NOPP's land acquisition was not free-of-charge but via compensation funds, with which to start up and progress forward.

Participatory nature of the engagements involved: Councillors, LCs, community and opinion leaders on one hand, with farmers, landlords, project staff, on the other hand. These measures ended in amicable agreements and in harmony. For instance. Negotiation was key because it resolved potential conflicts among land lords and tenants since some landlords were willing to give away land, yet the tenants were not open to negotiation.

While we saw light through negotiation some people failed to reach an agreement due to different interests and believes that the programme was political.

As an outcome, the project identified, mapped, and surveyed land. This was done with support from surveyors, and land-valuers. RTK machines were among the key tools utilized in the surveying land. Pangas and slashers were also employed to help in the land clearing to trace some boundaries and also use of surveying machines.

In all, previously negative minds turned positive to support the project. It was also to our surprise that even those who were invited for the meetings turned about in large numbers and were able to deliver information about the project.





## COMPENSATION FOR THE LAND ACQUIRED

People willing to give land for the project were compensated with start-up funds that could be utilized for re-investment by the former land lords. This followed a though process that involved identified land being validated, getting right owners for negation, valuation, surveying, accounts opening and transfer of funds to the right people that required compensation.

Profiling potential beneficiaries of the start-up funds from the NOPP was one of the key activities which the partners, communities and project staff and to follow-up to ensure that those that required compensation were identified and profiled.

Evaluation of the possible beneficiaries from the start-up funds then also followed with proper judgement on who is compensated, how much to compensate and also why not compensate especially those who were in the wetlands and other gazetted areas that needed to understand why less money for start-up was given or why anticipated start up fund will not be extended.

Mapping and negotiations with farmers that would be engaged in the start-up funds was another key activity that several of the farmers needed to undergo. This involved due diligence on who had what land and where, identifying absentee landlords and who is willing to offer the land for the project. This helped a lot to know who needed time the readiness of the farmers in the



context of supporting the project through the land that the project would then support.

■ Farmers were then sensitized on the next steps of the startup funds, how it will be paid, where to who which prepared their minds general planning of the resources that were yet to be received.

■ Generally those who were compensated with start-up funds were able to identify land elsewhere and they relocated, leaving the land for the project to start. Several of those that bought land they were able to create a good standard of living in their lives.

■ The processes of evaluation of land from willing seller were helpful because it that would form a basis for compensation.

■ This further facilitated the project in securing the land that was required natives for their activities like planting palm oil for their production

■ While it was a smooth process of the project securing land, and the start funds offered to the willing sellers, some people did not want their land evaluated as they did not want to relocate to another place and this is because some of them have cultural beliefs in places where they had which therefore slowed down process of evaluating land for the project.



Preparing land for palm oil growing



## SIGNING AGREEMENTS AND TRANSACTION PROCESS.

- In the process of securing the land for the project, there was signing of the agreements between willing buyer and willing seller. This was one of the better ways and alternatives to help the community members get the required compensation and start-up funds.
- To some extent some people were hesitant to take their agreements to finalize their the transactions because they thought that the project was going to take their land for free and any other related cases of land grabbing they had feared before.
- This came in a surprise of the landlords to think that the process of taking their land would not be compensated but through continuous sensitization, the story changed.
- It is also possible that since Buvuma had not seen or experienced the norms and practices of such engagements in projects like these, there was anxiety, fear of the unknown that majority overcame with time.
- Some community members were able to believe after seeing the lives of those who were compensated transforming with the funds that were compensated.
- The transaction process of the compensation funds was one that was not very familiar among the locals of Buvuma Island. It required majority to open up bank accounts which several of them required moving big distances, like Mukono town and other places. This was relevant to open up bank accounts because the project did not give money to willing sellers directly and to avoid overcrowding on the project office.
- Banks were considered to be more secure because when willing sellers money would be stolen especially if paid in cash, it would cause even more difficult problems to the community.
- To some extent, some people were not used to bank transactions a process that was not familiar to them, and also accessibility issues of the banks that were a bit far. It was also evident that because of the remoteness of the area community members were not much knowledgeable about bank transactions
- While some people did not expect to get money from the bank and they did not expect to open up accounts, it was the order of the day and several of them appreciated the process with time.
- The project start-up funds enabled the community members to kick off their activities and enable people who have given out their land to buy land elsewhere to support their livelihoods. They were compensated to improve their standards of living to ensure economic sustainability while some used the compensation to fund start-up businesses which employed many lives hence improved standards of living and economic development.



# LAND CONFLICT-RESOLUTION BUVUMA-STYLE

Salim Ruba Maiso, George Ssemugooma and Kyoziira Ssemwogerere



Buvuma may be an island, a small District and rarely in the mainstream media. But lately it has had a land conflict-resolution style or approach that the rest of Uganda and other interested communities can replicate and benefit from, according to the tales of **Salim Ruba Maiso, George Ssemugooma and Kyoziira Ssemwogerere**. These authors, who are local residents of Buvuma, took part in land request and acquisition processes

by Government, to establish oil palm-growing on the island (2014-todate).

Since land is a traditional key factor of production and a major asset in any investment, it had to be the most important ingredient government through the Agriculture Ministry, had to acquire first. It was one of the priorities of the National Oil Palm Project (NOPP).





**Source:** Internet

This was in Buvuma's Busamuzi town council, Nairambi and Buwooya sub-counties.

In the process of land acquisition, inevitably conflicts erupted arising from among others:

- unclear land boundaries
- absentee land lords
- some with titles that were not in their names

Since 2007, the NOPP staff, local community leaders and some communities had been working on land conflict resolution within the District, especially where the project would be situated. From the mentioned challenges that faced NOPP, the team undertook land conflict resolution approaches that among others, entailed:

1. thorough checks and balances on ownership of land
2. clearer boundaries mapping exercise.
3. proper land titles
4. community members of the Buwooya and Nairambi found it difficult to follow up on urgency to generate user-rights, so that the project would start.
5. reduction in the number of cases of land conflicts.
6. phase-by-phase negotiations
7. sensitization of the community on importance of peaceful conflict-resolution.

### **STRATEGY AND APPROACH:**

Community-based engagements [sit-to-resolve-differences-approach] or community meetings helped a lot in mapping the genesis of some of the



related conflicts on land and could easily find solutions. NOPP's deliberate support to communities to settle their land differences was very crucial. It led to a significant reduction in conflicts that culminated in majority accessing compensation funds in time.

This approach was bolstered by community members that were willing to offer land to support the project activities. Involvement of families in the land-related conflicts to create win-win situation, plus land committees explaining situations like those located in buffer zones that some residents wanted compensation, yet the project and guidelines wouldn't allow—all added helped settle explosive matters.

In some scenarios where some boundaries were not clear and more that one person claiming some section of land, they were encouraged to settle it and organize themselves while those whose tiles were not in there are names they were guided on the processes and procedures on how to follow it up which and when not followed up, would not allow the members to access compensation funds.

### MAJOR ACHIEVEMENTS.

The communities supported the project with the required land and majority have been compensated. That is 5000 hectares secured for nuclear estate and 2500 hectares for out growers.

The work is now going on the land as was required like nursery bed preparation, land clearing.

Majority of the people have got sensitized about the project what it will do and enable the community to achieve.

Most farmers have enough knowledge about NOPP and getting land for this project. The nursery bed is already mature-ready to grow

All the people who had complaints almost have transformed for better and are supporters of the project and some are now out grower farmers

### CHALLENGES FACED

There was some delay in the payments for the compensation of the funds for those with unresolved conflicts.

Some members had titles that were not in their names which also would not easily allow transactions procedures to be effected.

Some land boundaries were not clear and made it difficult to build consensus on some decision during conflict resolution.

Some lands are in Highly Conservation Areas which would not qualify for compensation.

Some land issues took longer than expected due to a long process by legal procedures.

Some lands are in buffer areas that were in conflict.

The youths have no land for growing oil palm yet they were interested.



# LEARNING FROM THE LESSONS ON ALTERNATIVE LIVELIHOOD STRATEGY FOR NATIONAL OIL PALM PROJECT BUVUMA.

By Nandudu Majorine, Tugezeeko Francis , Kibirango Margaret , Namutebi Hellen and Ssemakula Robert

6  
UN SDG

Ensure availability and sustainable management of water and sanitation for all



11  
UN SDG

Make cities and human settlements inclusive, safe, resilient and sustainable



15  
UN SDG

Protect, restore and promote sustainable use of terrestrial ecosystems, sustainably manage forests, combat desertification, and halt.



## INTRODUCTION

Alternative livelihood is one of the approaches and paths of development that has been mainstreamed to supplement the efforts of the oil palm growing and the general NOPP.

It has been established to provide alternative ways of survival for the agronomic communities in Buvuma. While land seemingly may be getting competitive for other investments, it is prudent that the communities of

Buwooya village, Nairambi, and Buvuma town council, Busamuzi subcounty, Buvuma main land not only think of crop growing and substance farming but also think of other ways of livelihoods as suggested by alternative livelihoods to help the communities adopt the new ways of living.

The objectives of alternative livelihood strategy hinges mainly on uplifting the welfare of non-oil palm growers, women, youth and children (Victims of the land



acquisition process) and bridge the income inequality gap between the direct beneficiaries of the oil palm and non-oil palm growers.

While there is a possibility of change in lifestyles, as people get more money, there may be need for more leisure activities, there is more on the required efforts to improve the health standards of the vulnerable communities through sensitization on gender based violence, more understanding of sexually transmitted diseases like HIV/AIDs, enterprise and skills development, gender main streaming, sanitation, nutrition, food security and financial literacy. All these may seem not to be direct on oil palm growing, but it is necessary for the changing and diverse communities for the people of Buvuma. The cross cutting element of the alternative livelihoods for the community is key in transforming the cross section of the communities that are not in the main stream of the oil palm growing in the District.

Since 2017 and inception of NOPP, there has been a deliberate effort by the NOPP to consider the alternative livelihoods of those not in mainstream oil palm growing lessons that have been drawn from other projects like Vegetable Oil Development projects that indicated the need for such intervention.

For its success, strategies like sensitizing communities about the programme, identification of mentee households and mentors, have been going on to ensure proper planning and implementation of the initiative.

In context, the fact that most of the people were dependent on agriculture and yet most of the land was divided between investment in the nucleus and households as nucleus estate this

created a gap for livelihood hence intervention for alternative livelihood program.

This is not the first intervention on livelihood that has been considered but there are others like Youth Livelihood Programme (YLP), UWEP- organizing women into development groups, Operation Wealth Creation (OWC)- preparing communities to participate in government programs which all will be working in context to support the alternative livelihoods of the communities.

The alternative livelihood programme has a particular focus on the vulnerable communities like the women and youth who have limited access to land, some elderly, and other landless categories in the communities to pickup livelihood opportunities from even off land.

Mobilizing and organizing of non-oil palm growers.

These were organized to engage in other enterprise selection and development within the identified communities of Buwooya village, Nairambi, and Buvuma town council, Busamuzi subcounty, Buvuma main land.

Mobilisation of these members, involved making courtesy calls with local leaders, planning meeting to learn more the situation with the vulnerable categories and approaches on how to involve relevant categories in the discussion about the community members in need. A total of about 17 sensitization meetings were conducted in the 17 parishes of Buvuma main sub counties. These helped the key stakeholders understand the proper concept of alternative livelihoods.



Some tools for data collection were developed to help generate data on the data. The needs assessment tools helped understand the needs of the identified communities and plan for the gap filling with the alternative livelihood programme for proper identification and planning of the engagements.

From the needs assessment the needy groups were identified, and guided to form groups according to enterprise needs which they formed and has been helpful in the outreach through the identified interventions.

### MAIN ACHIEVEMENTS.

The local leaders mobilized the non-oil palm growers for meetings who turned up in large numbers.

Detailed information about enterprise development was disseminated and appreciated and it guided the assessment exercise for the potential beneficiaries.

The community identified alternative needs for example piggery, poultry as key sources of their livelihoods.

34 groups were formed from 17 parishes from which the interventions on alternative livelihood will be extended.

The household mentees and mentor's selection criteria tools were developed to guide the process.

While good results were exhibited from the alternative livelihoods, there were some challenges like network problem



which hindered mobilization, difficulties in accessing some of the areas like the island parishes. Some members would turn up very late for the community sensitization meetings while others had very high expectations in regard to the programme and some times the concept of mentoring households was not easy for learners to understand.

From mobilization for engagements on alternative livelihoods, there was a very high turnout of participants more than expected as the demand for the services from alternative livelihood was overwhelming for the project. We didn't expect only 34 groups from the 17 parishes yet even people turned up in large numbers.

More still it was also established that more than 30% of the households had the ability to put up sanitation facilities like toilets but lacked the willingness to put them up, but from the sensitization process, they progressed positively to putting them up.



And some other participants in the project did not know the different roles of BIDCO and NOPP and would not easily know where and how to pledge allegiance in regard to project support.

### Model homes establishment

Model homes were established for those who were part of this programme of alternative livelihoods. This were established on the tenets of sanitation, hygiene and nutrition of non oil palm growers.

First a mapping exercise for households was done in 4 sub counties of Buwooya Nairambi, Busamuzi, and Buvuma town council .

This involved identification and registration of mentee households that were yet to be model homes once they adopted to the requirements and standards of a model homes as established by the standards of the alternative livelihood.

I identification and registration of mentee households was done with the help of tools and criteria that was

developed. The tools helped to identify the right target grouped that would work with the mentors to have the model homes in place.

Identification and selection of mentors for selected households was also done with each of the house holds selected linked to the mentor for support into the right sanitation process, nutrition processes, food security approaches and measures.

The house hold mentors had to undergo the right training to enable them match the needs of the mentees in working towards the model homes establishment in nutrition, sanitation, health and general households.

From this process, 90 mentors were identifies, and trained in mentoring house holds , while 450 households were identified and registered for the program in the 40 villages and 17 demonstration sites were established for other households to learn from.

While the model homes were established, it was a little difficult concept of mentoring households was not easy for learners to understand.

### Organizing non-oil palm growers into food production

This was quite an intensive process through which several community members were mobilized and sensitized to engage in high value food production. Majority of the community members on hearing the opportunity of oil palm production had oriented the efforts to the crop with limited attention to food production. The efforts through alternative livelihood helped the members to see the great opportunity and





market for the food produced by those not in oil palm production.

After the community members were mobilized and organized, they were trained in the on the profitable ventures and enterprises that could allow them get some money once they sell to those in other ventures.

Some demonstration sites for the identified crops were set up to encourage further learning and paractical skills for those that were interested to take the enterprises forward.

This interested farmers were then linking to the community input suppliers to be able to access seed, fertilizers, pesticides in case there was a need. This was a sustainable solution to support the efforts of those community members who were near by and would need the continuous supply of the community members.

Further to the linkages with the community suppliers for agricultural inputs, the trainings in agronomic practices were extended and further agricultural extension services to support them grow better the crops of choice.

Mainly, more than 150 farmers were able to adapt and practice the skills given to them in agronomy and crop growing.

### **Awareness about HIV/ AIDS**

The selected communities and homes were mobilizing through village announcements to enable the process of sensitization on HIV/ AIDS through the alternative livelihood programme.



17 HIV/AIDS awareness meetings were held in the 17 parishes of Buvuma mainland to enable them understand the risk of disease even as the income levels of the communities was yet to increase and maybe some prostitution on increase would put some of the communities of the mainland at risk of HIV/AIDS

Through this process, the Village health teams were identified, registered and trained Identification and registering and training of village health teams in counselling care and support .

There were trained in several roles including counseling, and Identifying, establishing and refilling condom dispensing points which would help many who need condoms access them while linking the patients in need to referral of patients to health facilities for further management .

This was an inclusive programme that enabled the communities learn on the risks that would ruin the lives of many o fthese community members to live healthy lives amidst the possible changes, lifestyles and vulnerability in the communities.



More than 17 communities were mobilized for the sensitization meetings and these communities were sensitized about HIV/AIDS knowledge especially prevention.

And 42 village health teams were identified, registered and trained in HIV/AIDS counselling, care and support while 84 condom dispensing points were identified established and refilled to enable distribution and easy access. HIV/AIDS patients that were identified and engaged were referred and linked from health services for proper engagement.

The team on the ground was challenged by low turn of some community members due to fear of stigmatization, and sometimes lack of feedback at the referral and linkage. There was also limited funds to sensitize many that would have needed the information. The focus of the alternative livelihoods was unique and essential that it provided skills development for the community members who were not in the mainstream oil palm growing communities.

It equipped the community with lifelong practical skills, facilitated the processes of self employment for people not in the project to earn a living and improve their living standards and have self-sustainable community economically and financially.

More so the programme was inclusive with participation of women, youth, and some men. In this context, it empowered communities with financial literacy skills, through a saving and credit scheme.

Economically majority of the women under this programme were equipped with knowledge and skills on saving, which enhanced their zeal for money utilisation, saving, investment in their

saving groups and building their capital base.

The women further started their small enterprises through their savings and loans from the groups revolving at a friendly cost which has improved their livelihood and empowerment economically.

Majority of the members in the community benefited from the programme much as at some point there was low turn up for the participants and some times there was a very long distance to the training centres where most of the capacity building sessions were organized.

The landscape was also not very friendly for the participants. The geographical nature of the area does not allow villages to be close and landscape composed of hills, swamps, rivers and rocks.

While we thought men would be more supportive to women joining groups as this would boost their family incomes and other accrued benefits, some women were refused by their husbands from joining saving groups thinking that women would spend a lot of time in groups neglecting their house chores, create negligence from their domestic roles and then could break their families.

Conclusively the programme of alternative livelihood was a well thought inclusive one leaving no one behind. Those in oil palm growing to benefit from the enterprise, those with no land and other productive resources for oil palm to follow through the angel of alternative livelihood which and when well utilized, would harness and support the efforts of programme with food production, off farm activities, labour.



# **GREAT REFINED PRODUCTS FROM OIL PALMS**

